Blocker Clustering

Log every blocker, cluster them by cause, and fix the cluster that costs the most days.

Manage Flow · Inspired by Klaus Leopold & Troy Magennis · Blocked Time · Root Causes

WORKED EXAMPLE · FICTIONAL TEAM

LEGEND

- Pink Sticky = One blocker
- Yellow Sticky = Cluster name

1 Blocker Log

ONE ROW PER BLOCKER · CAUSE, NOT PERSON

DATE	ITEM	BLOCKED BY (WHAT)	INSIDE / OUTSIDE TEAM	DAYS BLOCKED
3 Apr	Order history	Waiting for Payments sign-off	outside	3
8 Apr	Reorder events	Privacy sign-off	outside	4
10 Apr	Copy test data	No staging access	outside	2
15 Apr	Favourites API	Unclear acceptance criteria	inside	1
17 Apr	Checkout fix	Waiting for Payments sign-off	outside	2
22 Apr	Substitutes	Stock API not ready	outside	6
24 Apr	Price-change tag	Staging down	outside	1
29 Apr	Reorder button	Waiting for code review	inside	2
2 May	Promo price rules	Waiting for Payments sign-off	outside	3

2 Blocker Stickies

KEEP THEM AFTER THEY'RE CLEARED

- A pink sticky on the card the moment it's blocked
- Write the cause and the start date
- When it's cleared, add the days and move it here

Privacy sign-off: 4 days

No staging access: 2 days

Staging down: 1 day

Review wait: 2 days

Unclear criteria: 1 day

Sign-off: 3 days

3 Clusters

GROUP SIMILAR CAUSES · NAME EACH CLUSTER

Cluster: Sign-offs

Payments 3d · Privacy 4d · Payments 2d · Payments 3d

Count: 4 Days: 12

Cluster: Other teams' APIs

Stock API 6d

Count: 1 Days: 6

Cluster: Environments

Access 2d · Staging 1d

Count: 2 Days: 3

Cluster: Review waits

Code review 2d

Count: 1 Days: 2

Cluster: Unclear requirements

Criteria 1d

Count: 1 Days: 1

4 Fix the Biggest Cluster

BY TOTAL DAYS BLOCKED, NOT COUNT

Biggest cluster: sign-offs: 12 of 24 days

Root cause: every change waits for one person to approve it

Experiment to fix it: self-service checks for low-risk changes

Owner & review date: Tom, review on 6 June

5 Trend

IS IT WORKING?

PERIOD	BLOCKERS	DAYS BLOCKED
March	6	15
April	9	24

"What keeps blocking us, and what does it cost?"

"Which cluster, if we fixed it, would give us the most days back?"

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